

by the magnificent edifices, particularly of St. Peter's Church, the rare works of art, the vast St. Peter's Square, the colorful Papal Guards and the atmosphere of religious devotion that pervaded the Vatican.

Every night, after sightseeing the whole day, Rizal returned to his hotel, very tired. "I am tired as a dog," he wrote to Blumentritt, "but I will sleep as a god".⁸

After a week of wonderful sojourn in Rome, he prepared to return to the Philippines. He had already written to his father that he was coming home.

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Chapter 10

First Homecoming, 1887-88

All the alluring beauties of foreign countries and all the beautiful memories of his sojourn in alien lands could neither make Rizal forget his fatherland nor turn his back to his own nationality. True that he studied abroad, acquired the lore and languages of foreign nations, and enjoyed the friendship of many great men of the Western world; but he remained at heart a true Filipino with an unquenchable love for the Philippines and an unshakable determination to die in the land of his birth. Thus, after five years of memorable sojourn in Europe, he returned to the Philippines in August 1887 and practised medicine in Calamba. He lived the quiet life of a country doctor. But his enemies, who resented his *Noli*, persecuted him, even threatening to kill him.

Decision to Return Home. Because of the publication of the *Noli Me Tangere* and the uproar it caused among the friars, Rizal was warned by Paciano (his brother), Silvestre Ubaldo (his brother-in-law), Chengoy (Jose M. Cecilio), and other friends not to return home. But he did not heed their warning. He was determined to return to the Philippines for the following reasons: (1) to operate on his mother's eyes; (2) to serve his people who had long been oppressed by Spanish tyrants; (3) to find out for himself how the *Noli* and his other writings were affecting Filipinos and Spaniards in the Philippines; and (4) to inquire why Leonor Rivera remained silent.

In a letter to Blumentritt, written in Geneva on June 19, 1887, Rizal said: "Your advice that I live in Madrid and continue to write from there is very benevolent but I cannot accept it. I cannot endure the life in Madrid where everything is a voice in a wilderness. My parents want to see me, and I want to see

them also. All my life I desire to live in my country by the side of my family. Until now I am not Europeanized like the Filipinos of Madrid; I always like to return to the country of my birth".¹

In Rome, on June 29, 1887, Rizal wrote to his father, announcing his homecoming. "On the 15th of July, at the latest", he wrote, "I shall embark for our country, so that from the 15th to the 30th of August, we shall see each other".²

Delightful Trip to Manila. Rizal left Rome by train for Marseilles, a French port, which he reached without mishap. On July 3, 1887, he boarded the steamer *Djemnah*, the same steamer which brought him to Europe five years ago. There were about 50 passengers, including 4 Englishmen, 2 Germans, 3 Chinese, 2 Japanese, many Frenchmen, and 1 Filipino (Rizal).

Rizal was the only one among the passengers who could speak many languages, so that he acted as interpreter for his companions.³

The steamer was enroute to the Orient via the Suez Canal. Rizal thus saw this historic canal for the second time, the first time was when he sailed to Europe from Manila in 1882. On board, he played chess with fellow passengers and engaged in lively conversation in many languages. Some passengers sang; others played on the piano and accordion. After leaving Aden, the weather became rough and some of Rizal's books got wet.

At Saigon, on July 30, he transferred to another steamer *Haiphong* which was Manila-bound. On August 2, this steamer left Saigon for Manila.

Arrival in Manila. Rizal's voyage from Saigon to Manila was pleasant. On August 3rd the moon was full, and he slept soundly the whole night. The calm sea, illumined by the silvery moonlight, was a magnificent sight to him.

Near midnight of August 5, the *Haiphong* arrived in Manila. Rizal went ashore with a happy heart for he once more trod his beloved native soil. He stayed in the city for a short time to visit his friends. He found Manila the same as when he left it five years ago. There were the same old churches and buildings, the same holes in the roads, the same boats on the Pasig River, and the same heary walls surrounding the city.

Happy Homecoming. On August 8th, he returned to Calamba. His family welcomed him affectionately, with plentiful tears of joy. Writing to Blumentritt of his homecoming, he said: "I had a pleasant voyage. I found my family enjoying good health and our happiness was great in seeing each other again. They shed tears of joy and I had to answer ten thousand questions at the same time".⁴

The rejoicings of Rizal's return over, his family became worried for his safety. Paciano did not leave him during the first days after arrival to protect him from any enemy assault. His own father would not let him go out alone, lest something might happen to him.

In Calamba, Rizal established a medical clinic. His first patient was his mother, who was almost blind. He treated her eyes, but could not perform any surgical operation because her eye cataracts were not yet ripe. News of the arrival of a great doctor from Germany spread far and wide. Patients from Manila and the provinces flocked to Calamba. Rizal, who came to be called "Doctor Uliman" because he came from Germany, treated their ailments and soon he acquired a lucrative medical practice. His professional fees were reasonable, even gratis to the poor. Within a few months, he was able to earn P900 as a physician. By February, 1888, he earned a total of P5,000 as medical fees.

Unlike many successful medical practitioners, Rizal did not selfishly devote all his time to enriching himself. He opened a gymnasium for young folks, where he introduced European sports. He tried to interest his townmates in gymnastics, fencing and shooting so as to discourage the cockfights and gambling.⁵

Rizal suffered one failure during his six months of sojourn in Calamba — his failure to see Leonor Rivera. He tried to go to Dagupan, but his parents absolutely forbade him to go because Leonor's mother did not like him for a son-in-law. With a heavy heart, Rizal bowed to his parent's wish. He was caught within the iron grip of the custom of his time that marriages must be arranged by the parents of both groom and bride.

Storm over the Noli. Meanwhile, as Rizal was peacefully living in Calamba, his enemies plotted his doom. Aside from practising medicine, attending to his gymnasium, which he established, and taking part in the town's civic affairs, he painted

several beautiful landscapes and translated the German poems of Von Wildernath into Tagalog.

A few weeks after his arrival, a storm broke over his novel. One day Rizal received a letter from Governor General Emilio Terrero (1885-88) requesting him to come to Malacañan Palace. Somebody had whispered to the governor's ear that the *Noli* contained subversive ideas.

Rizal went to Manila and appeared at Malacañang. When he was informed by Governor General Terrero of the charge, he denied it, explaining that he merely exposed the truth, but he did not advocate subversive ideas. Pleased by his explanation and curious about the controversial book, the governor general asked the author for a copy of the *Noli* so that he could read it. Rizal had no copy then because the only copy he brought home was given to a friend. However, he promised to secure one for the governor general.

Rizal visited the Jesuit fathers to ask for the copy he sent them, but they would not part with it. The Jesuits, especially his former professors — Fr. Francisco de Paula Sanchez, Fr. Jose Bech, and Fr. Federico Faura — were glad to see him. He had a spirited discussion with Father Faura, who ventured an opinion that "everything in it was the truth", but added: "You may lose your head for it".

Fortunately, Rizal found a copy in the hands of a friend. He was able to get it and gave it to Governor General Terrero. The governor general, who was a liberal-minded Spaniard, knew that Rizal's life was in jeopardy because the friars were powerful. For security measure, he assigned a young Spanish lieutenant, Don Jose Taviel de Andrade, as bodyguard of Rizal. This lieutenant belonged to a noble family. He was cultured and knew painting, and could speak English, French, and Spanish.

Governor General Terrero read the *Noli* and found nothing wrong with it. But Rizal's enemies were powerful. The Archbishop of Manila, Msgr. Pedro Payo (a Dominican) sent a copy of the *Noli* to Father Rector Gregorio Echavarria of the University of Santo Tomas for examination by a committee of the faculty. The committee, which was composed of Dominican professors, submitted its report to the Father Rector, who immediately transmitted it to Archbishop Payo. The archbishop,

in turn, lost no time in forwarding it to the governor general. This report of the faculty members of the University of Santo Tomas stated that the *Noli* was "heretical, impious, and scandalous in the religious order, and anti-patriotic, subversive of public order, injurious to the government of Spain and its function in the Philippine Islands in the political order".⁶

Governor General Terrero was dissatisfied with the report of the Dominicans, for he knew that the Dominicans were prejudiced against Rizal. He sent the novel to the Permanent Commission of Censorship which was composed of priests and laymen. The report of this commission was drafted by its head, Fr. Salvador Font, Augustinian cura of Tondo, and submitted to the governor general on December 29. It found the novel to contain subversive ideas against the Church and Spain, and recommended "that the importation, reproduction and circulation of this pernicious book in the islands be absolutely prohibited".⁷

When the newspapers published Font's written report of the censorship commission, Rizal and his friends became apprehensive and uneasy. The enemies of Rizal exulted in unholy glee. The banning of the *Noli* only served to make it popular. Everybody wanted to read it. News about the great book spread among the masses. What the hated Spanish masters did not like, the oppressed masses liked very much. Despite the government prohibition and the vigilance of the cruel Guardia Civil many Filipinos were able to get hold of copies of the *Noli* which they read at night behind closed doors.

Thanks to Governor General Terrero, there were no mass imprisonment or mass execution of Filipinos. He refused to be intimidated by the friars who clamored for harsh measures against people caught reading the novel and its author.

Attackers of the *Noli*. The battle over the *Noli* took the form of a virulent war of words. Father Font printed his report and distributed copies of it in order to discredit the controversial novel. Another Augustinian, Fr. Jose Rodriguez, Prior of Guadalupe, published a series of eight pamphlets under the general heading *Cuestiones de Sumo Interes* (Questions of Supreme Interest) to blast the *Noli* and other anti-Spanish writings. These eight pamphlets were entitled as follows:

1. *Porque no los he de leer?* (Why Should I not Read Them?).
2. *Guardaos de ellos. Porque?* (Beware of Them. Why?).
3. *¿Que me dice usted de la peste?* (And What Can You Tell Me of Plague?).
4. *Porque triunfan los impios?* (Why Do the Impious Triumph?).
5. *Cree usted que de veras no hay purgatorio?* (Do You Think There Is Really No Purgatory?).
6. *Hay o no hay infierno?* (Is There or Is There No Hell?).
7. *Que le parece a usted de esos libelos?* (What Do You Think of These Libels?).
8. *Confesion o condenacion?* (Confession or Damnation?).

Copies of these anti-Rizal pamphlets written by Fray Rodriguez were sold daily in the churches after Mass. Many Filipinos were forced to buy them in order not to displease the friars, but they did not believe what their author said with hysterical fervor.

Repercussions of the storm over the *Noli* reached Spain. It was fiercely attacked on the session hall of the Senate of the Spanish Cortes by various senators, particularly General Jose de Salamanca on April 1, 1888, General Luis M. de Pando on April 12, and Sr. Fernando Vida on June 11. The Spanish academician of Madrid, Vicente Barrantes, who formerly occupied high government positions in the Philippines, bitterly criticized the *Noli* in an article published in *La España Moderna* (a newspaper of Madrid) in January, 1890.

Defenders of the *Noli*. The much-maligned *Noli* had its gallant defenders who fearlessly came out to prove the merits of the novel or to refute the arguments of the unkind attackers. Marcelo H. del Pilar, Dr. Antonio Ma. Regidor, Graciano Lopez Jaena, Mariano Ponce, and other Filipino reformists in foreign lands, of course, rushed to uphold the truths of the *Noli*. Father Sanchez, Rizal's favorite teacher at the Ateneo, defended and praised it in public. Don Segismundo Moret, former Minister of the Crown; Dr. Miguel Morayta, historian and statesman; and Professor Blumentritt, scholar and educator, read and liked the novel.

A brilliant defense of the *Noli* came from an unexpected source. It was by Rev. Vicente Garcia, a Filipino Catholic priest-scholar, a theologian of the Manila Cathedral, and a Tagalog translator of the famous Imitation of Christ by Thomas a Kempis. Father Garcia, writing under the penname Justo Desiderio Magalang, wrote a defense of the *Noli* which was published in Singapore as an appendix to a pamphlet dated July 18, 1888. He blasted the arguments of Fr. Rodriguez as follows:

1. Rizal cannot be an "ignorant man", as Fr. Rodriguez alleged, because he was a graduate of Spanish universities and was a recipient of scholastic honors.

2. Rizal does not attack the Church and Spain, as Fr. Rodriguez claimed, because what Rizal attacked in the *Noli* were the bad Spanish officials and not Spain, and the bad and corrupt friars and not the Church.

3. Father Rodriguez said that those who read the *Noli* commit a mortal sin; since he (Rodriguez) had read the novel, therefore he also commits a mortal sin.

Later, when Rizal learned of the brilliant defense of Father Garcia of his novel, he cried because his gratitude was overwhelming.⁸ Rizal, himself defended his novel against Barrantes' attack, in a letter written in Brussels, Belgium, in February, 1880. In this letter, he exposed Barrantes' ignorance of Philippine affairs and mental dishonesty which is unworthy of an academician.⁹ Barrantes met in Rizal his master in satire and polemics.

During the days when the *Noli* was the target of a heated controversy between the friars (and their minions) and the friends of Rizal, all copies of it were sold out and the price per copy soared to unprecedented level. Both friends and enemies of the *Noli* found it extremely difficult to secure a copy. According to Rizal, in a letter to Fernando Canon from Geneva, June 13, 1887, the price he set per copy was five pesetas (equivalent to one peso), but the price later rose to fifty pesos per copy.

Rizal and Taviel de Andrade. While the storm over the *Noli* was raging in fury, Rizal was not molested in Calamba. This is due to Governor General Terrero's generosity in assigning a bodyguard to him. Between this Spanish bodyguard, Lt. Jose Taviel de Andrade, and Rizal, a beautiful friendship bloomed.

Together, Rizal and Andrade, both young, educated and cultured, made walking tours of the verdant countrysides, discussed topics of common interest, and enjoyed fencing, shooting, hunting and painting. Lt. Andrade became a great admirer of the man he was ordered to watch and protect. Years later, he wrote of Rizal: "Rizal was refined, educated and gentlemanly. The hobbies that most interested him were hunting, fencing, shooting, painting, and hiking . . . I well remember our excursion to Mount Makiling, not so much for the beautiful view . . . as for the rumors and pernicious effects that result from it. There was one who believed and reported to Manila that Rizal and I, at the top of the mountain, hoisted the German flag and proclaimed its sovereignty over the Philippines. I imagined that such nonsense emanated from the friars of Calamba, but did not take the trouble to make inquiries about the matter".¹⁰

What marred Rizal's happy days in Calamba with Lt. Andrade were (1) the death of his older sister, Olympia, and (2) the groundless tales circulated by his enemies that he was "a German spy, an agent of Bismarck, a Protestant, a Mason, a witch, a soul beyond salvation, etc."¹¹

Calamba's Agrarian Trouble. Governor General Terrero, influenced by certain facts in *Noli Me Tangere*, ordered a government investigation of the friar estates to remedy whatever iniquities might have been present in connection with land taxes and with tenant relations. One of the friar estates affected was the Calamba Hacienda which the Dominican Order owned since 1883. In compliance with the governor general's orders, dated December 30, 1887, the Civil Governor of Laguna Province directed the municipal authorities of Calamba to investigate the agrarian conditions of their locality.

Upon hearing of the investigation, the Calamba folks solicited Rizal's help in gathering the facts and listing their grievances against the hacienda management, so that the central government might institute certain agrarian reforms.

After a thorough study of the conditions in Calamba, Rizal wrote down his findings which the tenants and three of the officials of the hacienda signed on January 8, 1888. These findings, which were formally submitted to the government for action, were the following:¹²

1. The hacienda of the Dominican Order comprised not only the lands around Calamba, but also the town of Calamba.

2. The profits of the Dominican Order continually increased because of the arbitrary increase of the rentals paid by the tenants.

3. The hacienda owner never contributed a single centavo for the celebration of the town fiesta, for the education of the children, and for the improvement of agriculture.

4. Tenants who had spent much labor in clearing the lands were dispossessed of said lands for flimsy reasons.

5. High rates of interest were charged the tenants for delayed payment of rentals, and when the rentals could not be paid, the hacienda management confiscated their carabaos, tools, and homes.

Farewell to Calamba. Rizal's exposure of the deplorable conditions of tenancy in Calamba infuriated further his enemies. The friars exerted pressure on Malacañan Palace to eliminate him. They asked Governor General Terrero to deport him, but the latter refused because there was no valid charge against Rizal in court. Anonymous threats against Rizal's life were received by his parents. The alarmed parents, relatives and friends (including Lt. Taviel de Andrade) advised him to go away, for his life was in danger.

One day Governor General Terrero summoned Rizal and "advised" him to leave the Philippines for his own good. He was giving Rizal a chance to escape the fury of the friars' wrath.

This time Rizal had to go. He could not very well disobey the governor general's veiled orders. But he was not running like a coward from a fight. He was courageous, a fact which his worst enemies could not deny. A valiant hero that he was, he was not afraid of any man and neither was he afraid to die. He was compelled to leave Calamba for two reasons: (1) his presence in Calamba was jeopardizing the safety and happiness of his family and friends and (2) he could fight better his enemies and serve his country's cause with greater efficacy by writing in foreign countries.

A Poem for Lipa. Shortly before Rizal left Calamba in 1888 his friend from Lipa requested him to write a poem in commem-

oration of the town's elevation to a villa (city) by virtue of the Becerra Law of 1888. Gladly, he wrote a poem dedicated to the industrious folks of Lipa. This was the "*Himno Al Trabajo*" (Hymn to Labor). He finished it and sent it to Lipa before his departure from Calamba. It runs as follows:¹³

HYMN TO LABOR

CHORUS:

For our country in war,
For our country in peace
The Filipino will be ready,
While he lives and when he dies.

MEN:

As soon as the East is tinted with light
Forth to the fields to plow the loam!
Since it is work that sustains the man,
The motherland, family and the home.
Hard though the soil may prove to be,
Implacable the sun above,
For motherland, our wives and babes,
'Twill be easy with our love.

WIVES:

Courageously set out to work.
Your home is safe with a faithful wife
Implanting in her children, love
For wisdom, land, and virtuous life.
When nightfall brings us to our rest,
May smiling fortune guard our door;
But if cruel fate should harm her man,
The wife would toil on as before.

GIRLS:

Hail! Hail! Give praise to work!
The country's vigour and her wealth;
For work lift up your brow serene
It is your blood, your life, your health.
If any youth protests his love
His work shall prove if he be good.

That man alone who strives and toils
Can find the way to feed his brood.

BOYS:

Teach us then the hardest tasks
For down thy trails we turn our feet
That when our country calls tomorrow
Thy purposes we may complete.
And may our elders say, who see us,
See! How worthy of their sires!
No incense can exalt our dead ones
Like a brave son who aspires!

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Chapter 11

In Hong Kong and Macao, 1888

Hounded by powerful enemies, Rizal was forced to leave his country for a second time in February 1888. He was then a full-grown man of 27 years of age, a practising physician, and a recognized man-of-letters. The first time he went abroad in June 1882, he was a mere lad of 21, a youthful student in search of wisdom in the Old World, a romantic idealist with beautiful dreams of emancipating his people from bondage by the magic power of his pen. Times had changed. Rizal at 27 was an embittered victim of human iniquities, a disillusioned dreamer, a frustrated reformer.

The Trip to Hong Kong. On February 3, 1888, after a short stay of six months in his beloved Calamba, Rizal left Manila for Hong Kong on board the *Zafiro*. He was sick and sad during the crossing of the choppy China Sea. He did not get off his ship when it made brief stopover at Amoy on February 7. For three reasons: (1) he was not feeling well, (2) it was raining hard, and (3) he heard that the city was dirty. He arrived in Hong Kong on February 8.

During his stay in Hong Kong, a British colony, Rizal wrote a letter to Blumentritt, dated February 16, 1888, expressing his bitterness. This letter runs as follows:¹

At last I can write freely. At last I can express my thoughts without fear of censorship from the chief! They forced me to leave my country. Half sick I left the house.

Oh, dear Blumentritt, you have no idea of my minor odyssey. Without the aid of my friend Lieutenant Taviel de

Andrade, what would become of me! Without the sympathies of the Governor General, the directors of the civil administration and civil government, I would now be in some dungeon.

All the provincials and the archbishop went daily to the Governor General to complain against me. The Syndic of the Dominicans wrote a denunciation to the alcalde that at night they saw me hold secret meetings with men and women on top of a hill. It is true I went walking at dawn to a hill accompanied by many men, women, and children, for the purpose of enjoying the coolness of the morning, but always escorted by the lieutenant of the Guardia Civil who knows Tagalog. Who is the conspirator of secret sessions that will hold them in the open air among women and children? I allowed the accusation to reach the Governor General so he could see what kind of enemies I have.

My countrymen offered me money to leave the islands. They asked me to do so not only for my own interest but also theirs, because I have many friends and acquaintances whom they would have deported with me to Balabag or the Marianas Islands. Thus, half sick, I bade a hasty farewell to my family. I am returning to Europe by way of Japan and the United States. We should see each other again. I have so much to tell you.

In Hong Kong, Rizal stayed at Victoria Hotel. He was welcomed by the Filipino residents, including Jose Maria Basa, Balbino Mauricio, and Manuel Yriarte (son of Francisco Yriarte, alcalde mayor of Laguna).

A Spaniard, Jose Sainz de Varanda, who was a former secretary of Governor General Terrero, shadowed Rizal's movement in Hong Kong. It is believed that he was commissioned by the Spanish authorities to spy on Rizal.

"Hong Kong," wrote Rizal to Blumentritt on February 16, 1888, "is a small, but very clean city. Many Portuguese, Hindus, English, Chinese, and Jews live in it. There are some Filipinos, the majority of whom being those who had been exiled to the Marianas Islands in 1872. They are poor, gentle, and timid. Formerly they were rich mechanics, industrialists, and financiers."²

Visit to Macao. On February 18, Rizal, accompanied by Basa, boarded the ferry steamer *Kiu-Kiang* for Macao. He was surprised to see among the passengers a familiar figure — Sainz de Varanda.

Macao is a Portuguese colony near Hong Kong. "The city of Macao," wrote Rizal, in his diary, "is small, low, and gloomy. There are many junks, sampans, but few steamers. It looks sad and is almost dead."³

In Macao, Rizal and Basa stayed at the home of Don Juan Francisco Lecaros, a Filipino gentleman married to a Portuguese lady. He was rich and spent his days cultivating plants and flowers, many of which came from the Philippines.

During his two-day sojourn in Macao, Rizal visited the theatre, casino, cathedral and churches, pagodas, botanical garden, and bazaars. He also saw the famous Grotto of Camoens, Portugal's national poet. In the evening of February 19, he witnessed a Catholic procession, in which the devotees were dressed in blue and purple dresses and were carrying unlighted candles.

On February 20, Rizal and Basa returned to Hong Kong, again on board the ferry steamer *Kiu Kiang*.

Experiences in Hong Kong. During his two-week visit in Hong Kong, Rizal studied Chinese life, language, drama, and customs. He wrote down in his own diary the following experiences:⁴

1. Noisy celebration of the Chinese New Year which lasted from February 11th (Saturday) to 13th (Monday). Continuous explosions of firecrackers. The richer the Chinese, the more firecrackers he exploded. Rizal himself fired many firecrackers at the window of his hotel.

2. Boisterous Chinese theatre, with noisy audience and noisier music. In the Chinese dramatic art, Rizal observed the following: (1) a man astride a stick means a man riding on horseback, (2) an actor raising his leg means he is entering a house, (3) a red dress indicates a wedding, (4) a girl about to be married coyly covers her face with a fan even in the presence of her fiance, and (5) a man raising a whip signifies he is about to ride a horse.

3. The marathon lauriat party, wherein the guests were served numerous dishes, such as dried fruits, geese, shrimps, century eggs, shark fins, bird nests, white ducks, chicken with vinegar, fish heads, roasted pigs, tea, etc. The longest meal in the world.

4. The Dominican Order was the richest religious order in Hong Kong. It engaged actively in business. It owned more than 700 houses for rent and many shares in foreign banks. It had millions of dollars deposited in the banks which earned fabulous interests.

5. Of the Hong Kong cemeteries belonging to the Protestants, Catholics, and Muslims, that of the Protestants was the most beautiful because of its well-groomed plants and clean pathways. The Catholic cemetery was most pompous, with its ornate and expensive mausoleums and extravagantly carved sepulchers. The Muslim cemetery was the simplest, containing only a little mosque and tombstones with Arabic inscriptions.

Departure From Hong Kong. On February 22, 1888, Rizal left Hong Kong on board the *Oceanic*, an American steamer. His destination was Japan. He did not like the meals on board, but he liked the ship because it was clean and efficiently managed. His cabinmate was a British Protestant missionary who had lived in China for 27 years and knew the Chinese language very well. Rizal called him "a good man".⁵

Other passengers, with whom Rizal conversed in their own languages, were two Portuguese, two Chinese, several British, and an American woman Protestant missionary.

Chapter 12

Romantic Interlude in Japan (1888)

One of the happiest interludes in the life of Rizal was his sojourn in the Land of the Cherry Blossoms for one month and a half (February 28 — April 13, 1888). He was enchanted by the natural beauty of Japan, the charming manners of the Japanese people, and the picturesque shrines. Moreover, he fell in love with a Japanese girl, whose loveliness infused joy and romance in his sorrowing heart. Her real name was Seiko Usui. Rizal affectionately called her O-Sei-San. Fate, however, cut short his happy days in Japan. He had to sacrifice his own happiness to carry on his work for the redemption of his oppressed people.

Rizal Arrives in Yokohama. Early in the morning of Tuesday, February 28, 1888, Rizal arrived in Yokohama. He registered at the Grand Hotel.

The next day he proceeded to Tokyo and took a room at Tokyo Hotel, where he stayed from March 2 to 7. He was impressed by the city of Tokyo. He wrote to Professor Blumentritt: "Tokyo is more expensive than Paris. The walls are built in cyclopean manner. The streets are large and wide."¹

Rizal in Tokyo. Shortly after Rizal's arrival in Tokyo, he was visited at his hotel by Juan Perez Caballero, secretary of the Spanish Legation. The latter invited him to live at the Spanish Legation.

Rizal, being an intelligent man, realized that the Spanish diplomatic authorities were instructed from Manila to monitor his movements in Japan. He accepted the invitation for two

reasons: (1) he could economize his living expenses by staying at the legation and (2) he had nothing to hide from the prying eyes of the Spanish authorities.

On March 7, Rizal checked out of Tokyo Hotel and lived at the Spanish Legation. He and Perez Caballero became good friends. In a letter to Blumentritt, he described the Spanish diplomat as "a young, fine, and excellent writer" and "an able diplomat who had traveled much".²

During his first day in Tokyo, Rizal was embarrassed because he did not know the Japanese language. He looked like a Japanese, but could not talk Japanese. He had a hard time shopping, for he could not be understood and the Japanese children laughed at him. Thus he wrote to Blumentritt. "Here you have your friend, Rizal the wonder of the Japanese, who has the face of a Japanese but does not speak Japanese. On the streets, when I go shopping, people look at me and ill-educated children laugh because I speak such a strange language. In Tokyo very few persons speak English, but in Yokohama many speak it. Some believe I am an Europeanized Japanese who does not want to be taken as such."³

To avoid further embarrassment, Rizal decided to study the Japanese language. Being a born linguist, he was able to speak it within a few days. He also studied the Japanese drama (kabuki), arts, music, and judo (Japanese art of self-defense). He browsed in the museums, libraries, art galleries, and shrines. He visited Meguro, Nikko, Hakone, Miyashita, and the charming villages of Japan.

Rizal and the Tokyo Musicians. One cool afternoon in March, 1888, Rizal was promenading in a street of Tokyo near a park. It was a beautiful spring afternoon. There were many people at the park.

As he approached the park, Rizal heard the Tokyo band playing a classical work of Strauss. He was impressed by the superb performances of the Western music. He stopped and listened in rapt attention. He thought: "How admirable was the rendition. I wonder how these Japanese people have assimilated the modern European music to the extent of playing the beautiful musical masterpieces of the great European composers so well!"

The band stopped playing. The musicians descended from the bandstand and walked around for a rest. Some began to converse. To Rizal's amazement, they were talking in Tagalog. He approached them, inquiring in Tagalog: "Paisano, taga saan po kayo?" (Compatriot, where are you from?).

The musicians were equally surprised and delighted to meet him.⁴ They told him they were Filipinos and that the principal instruments in the band were Japanese, but they were playing only the secondary instruments.

Rizal's Impression of Japan. Rizal was favorably impressed by Japan. He was a keen observer, taking copious notes on the life, customs, and culture of the people. He was no silly, light-headed tourist who merely enjoys attractive sights that appealed only to the senses. The things which favorably impressed Rizal in Japan were:⁵

1. The beauty of the country — its flowers, mountains, streams, and scenic panoramas.
2. The cleanliness, politeness, and industry of the Japanese people.
3. The picturesque dress and simple charm of the Japanese women.
4. There were very few thieves in Japan so that the houses remained open day and night, and in the hotel room one could safely leave money on the table.
5. Beggars were rarely seen in the city streets, unlike in Manila and other cities.

However, there is one thing which he did not like in Japan, and that was the popular mode of transportation by means of rickshaws drawn by men. His sensitive soul recoiled at seeing human beings working like horses, pulling the carts called rickshaws. He felt disgusted at the way a human being was employed like a horse.⁶

Romance with O-Sei-San. One spring afternoon, a few days after he had moved to the Spanish Legation in the Azabu district of Tokyo, Rizal saw a pretty Japanese girl walking past the legation gate. Being a man with an eye for feminine beauty, he was attracted by her regal loveliness and charm. He craved to meet her — but how?

Rizal made inquiries among the legation employees and learned from one of them (a Japanese gardener) that she was Seiko Usui, who lived in her parents' home and that she used to pass by the legation during her daily afternoon walk.

The following afternoon, Rizal and the Japanese gardener waited at the legation gate and watched for the girl. As she approached, he took off his hat and politely introduced himself, as was the custom in Germany. At that time, Rizal's Japanese was still very poor so that the gardener came to his aid and explained to the girl that the young man was a physician from Manila who was a guest of the Spanish Legation.

Seiko-san was mildly amused at the gallant gentleman from the Philippines who spoke in halting Japanese. She replied in English, for she knew that language and also French. The two then conversed in both English and French — the language barrier was thus eliminated.

Since that first meeting, Rizal and O-Sei-San, as Rizal called her, met almost daily. Together, they visited the interesting spots of the city — the Imperial Art Gallery, the Imperial Library, the universities, the Shokubutsu-en (Botanical Garden), the city parks (particularly Hibiya Park), and the picturesque shrines.

Both found happiness in each other's company. Rizal was then a lonely physician of 27 years old, disillusioned by his frustrated romance with Leonor Rivera and embittered by Spanish injustices at home. O-Sei-San was a lonely samurai's daughter of 23 years old and had never yet experienced the ecstasy of true love. Affinity of interest in the arts paved the way for their romance.

Rizal saw in lovely O-Sei-San the qualities of his ideal womanhood — beauty, charm, modesty, and intelligence. No wonder, he fell deeply in love with her. O-Sei-San reciprocated his affection, for it was the first time her heart palpitated with joys to see a man of gallantry, dignity, courtesy, and versatile talents.

O-Sei-San helped Rizal in many ways. More than a sweetheart, she was his guide, interpreter, and tutor. She guided him in observing the shrines and villages around Tokyo. She improved his knowledge of Nippongo (Japanese language) and

Japanese history. And she interpreted for him the Kabuki plays and the quaint customs and mores of the Japanese people.

O-Sei-San's beauty and affection almost tempted Rizal to settle down in Japan. At the same time, he was offered a good job at the Spanish Legation. If he were a man of lesser heroic mould, of lesser will power, he would have lived permanently in Japan — and happily at that with O-Sei-San; but then the world, in general, and the Philippines, in particular, would have lost a Rizal.

Rizal on O-Sei-San. Rizal's great love for O-Sei-San is attested by the hero's diary. On the eve of his departure, he wrote in his diary:⁸

"Japan has enchanted me. The beautiful scenery, the flowers, the trees, and the inhabitants — so peaceful, so courteous, and so pleasant. O-Sei-San, Sayonara, Sayonara! I have spent a happy golden month; I do not know if I can have another one like that in all my life. Love, money, friendship, appreciation, honors — these have not been wanting.

To think that I am leaving this life for the uncertain, the unknown. There I was offered an easy way to live, beloved and esteemed.

To you I dedicate the final chapter of these memoirs of my youth. No woman, like you, has ever loved me. No woman, like you has ever sacrificed for me. Like the flower of the chodji that falls from the stem fresh and whole without falling leaves or without withering — with poetry still despite its fall — thus you fell. Neither have you lost your purity nor have the delicate petals of your innocence faded — Sayonara, Sayonara!

You shall never return to know that I have once more thought of you and that your image lives in my memory; and undoubtedly, I am always thinking of you. Your name lives in the sight of my lips, your image accompanies and animates all my thoughts. When shall I return to pass another divine afternoon like that in the temple of Meguro? When shall the sweet hours I spent with you return? When shall I find them sweeter, more tranquil, more pleasing? You the color of the camellia, its freshness, its elegance.

Ah! last descendant of a noble family, faithful to an unfortunate vengeance, you are lovely like . . . everything has ended! Sayonara, Sayonara!

With this tenderly tragic entry in his own diary, Rizal bade farewell to lovely O-Sei-San.⁹

Sayonara, Japan. On April 13, 1888, Rizal boarded the *Belgic*, an English steamer, at Yokohama, bound for the United States. He left Japan with a heavy heart, for he knew that he would never again see this beautiful "Land of the Cherry Blossoms" and his beloved O-Sei-San. Truly, his sojourn in Japan for 45 days was one of the happiest interludes in his life.

O-Sei-San After Rizal's Departure. As everything on earth has to end, the beautiful romance between Rizal and O-Sei-San inevitably came to a dolorous ending. Sacrificing his personal happiness, Rizal had to carry on his libertarian mission in Europe, accordingly, he resumed his voyage, leaving behind the lovely O-Sei-San, whom he passionately loved.

Broken-hearted by the departure of Rizal, the first man to capture her heart, O-Sei-San mourned for a long time the loss of her lover. Eventually, she became resigned to her fate, cherishing unto death the nostalgic memories of her romance with Rizal.¹⁰

About 1897, a year after Rizal's execution, she married Mr. Alfred Charlton, British teacher of chemistry of the Peers' School in Tokyo. Their wedlock was blessed by only one child — a daughter named Yuriko. After many years of teaching, Charlton was awarded by the Japanese government with an imperial decoration — Order of Merit, 5th Class. He died on November 2, 1915, survived by O-Sei-San, whose real name was Seiko Usui, and their daughter Yuriko. This daughter later married Yoshiharu Takiguchi, son of a Japanese senator.

Mrs. Charlton (O-Sei-San), as a widow, lived in a comfortable home in Shinjuko district, Tokyo. She survived World War II, but her home was destroyed in 1944 by the U.S. bombing of Tokyo. She died on May 1, 1947 at the age of 80. She was buried in her husband's tomb at Zoshigawa Cemetery. A Japanese inscription on their tomb reads as follows:

**Alfred Charlton, 5th Order of Merit, and
wife Seiko**

Voyage Across the Pacific. Despite his sorrowing heart, Rizal enjoyed the pleasant trans-Pacific voyage to the United States. On board the ship, he met a semi-Filipino family — Mr. Reinaldo Turner, his wife Emma Jackson (daughter of an Englishman, their children, and their maid servant from Pangasinan).¹⁰

One day one of the children, a bright young boy, asked Rizal:

"Do you know, sir, a famous man in Manila named Richal? He wrote a novel, *Noli Me Tangere*."

"Yes, hijo, I am Richal," replied Rizal.

In great joy the boy rushed to his mother, informing her that the famous man is their fellow passenger, she felicitated Rizal, feeling proud that they were travelling with a celebrity.

Rizal and Tetcho. Another passenger which Rizal befriended on board the *Belgic* was Tetcho Suehiro, a fighting Japanese journalist, novelist, and champion of human rights, who was forced by the Japanese government to leave the country, just as Rizal was compelled to leave the Philippines by the Spanish authorities. At the beginning of the voyage from Yokohama, Tetcho was miserably alone, for he knew only his own Japanese language and so he could not communicate with the ship officers and the passengers. Learning of his predicament, Rizal, who knew many foreign languages, including Japanese, befriended him and acted as his interpreter during their long trip from Yokohama to San Francisco, across the U.S. to New York until they reached London, where they parted.

Rizal and Tetcho were kindred spirits. Both were valiant patriots, implacable foes of injustice and tyranny. Both were men of peace using their trenchant pens as formidable weapons to fight for their peoples' welfare and happiness.

Rizal told Tetcho the story of his life's mission to emancipate his oppressed people from Spanish tyranny and of the persecutions which he and his family suffered from the vindictive Spanish officials and bad friars, causing him to flee to foreign countries where he could freely carry on his libertarian activities. During their intimate acquaintanceship of almost eight months (April 13-December 1, 1888) Tetcho came to admire Rizal, whose patriotism and magnificent talents greatly fascinated him and

influenced him to fortify his own crusade for human rights in his own country.

On December 1, 1888, after a last warm handshake and bidding each other "goodbye," Rizal and Tetcho parted ways — never to meet again. Rizal remained in London to conduct historical researches on Mora at the British Museum, while Tetcho returned to Japan.

In 1889, shortly after his return to Japan, he published his travel diary which contained his impressions of Rizal, as follows:¹¹

"Mr. Rizal was a citizen of Manila in the Philippines. Age about 27 to 29. Young as he was, he was proficient in seven languages."

"It was in *S/S Belgic* that we first met. I came to England by way of America with him. Ever since I had been inter-coursing with him."

"Rizal was an open-hearted man. He was not hair-splitting. He was an accomplished, good at picture, skillful in exquisite wax work, especially."

"I arrived at London late in May, 1888. I temporarily stayed at "King Henry's Road," then moved to Room 56 of Parliament Hill Road. I intended to stay here until February or March, but unfortunately London had been shrouded by fog since early October. I have a slight illness, and it appeared to be very hard for me to spend the coming winter here. I decided to go home, and scheduled to leave London on December the First."

"On December the First, I got up early. It was a fine sunny day, after uncomfortable days of fog and rain. The sun rose as if it congratulated my lucky departure for home. I took a farewell of my people and at 9:30 A.M. when I was going down the Parliament Hill Road, I met Mr. Rizal coming up to my hotel. I called him to ride with me on the coach. Mr. Rizal came from Manila. He has a good command of seven different foreign languages at the age of only twenty-seven. . . . He was a frank and daring fellow, fond of various arts, especially good at dearing. . . ."

After the publication of his travel diary, Tetcho resigned his position as editor of Tokyo newspaper, *Choya*, and entered politics. In 1890 he was elected as member of the lower house of the First Imperial Diet (Japanese parliament), where he carried on his fight for human rights. The following year (1891) he published a political novel titled *Nankai-no-Daiharan* (Storm Over The South Sea) which resembles Rizal's *Noli Me Tangere* in plot. Three years later (1894) he published another novel entitled *O-unabara* (The Big Ocean) which was similar to *El Filibusterismo*.

While still a member of the Imperial Diet, Tetcho died of heart attack in Tokyo in February, 1896 (ten months before Rizal's execution). He was then 49 years old.

Chapter 13

Rizal's Visit to the United States (1888)

Rizal first saw America on April 28, 1888. His arrival in this great country was marred by racial prejudice, for he saw the discriminatory treatment of the Chinese and the Negroes by the white Americans. He kept notes of what he observed during his trip from San Francisco to New York, where he took a ship for England. From his notes and his letters to his friends, we get a wealth of first-hand impressions of America, some of which were rather unfavorable but true. Rizal was a man of truth, and he wrote what he had seen and experienced.

Arrival in San Francisco. The steamer *Belgic*, with Rizal on board, docked at San Francisco on Saturday morning, April 28, 1888. All passengers were not allowed to land. The American health authorities placed the ship under quarantine on the ground that it came from the Far East where a cholera epidemic was alleged to be raging. Rizal was surprised because he knew there was no cholera epidemic at that time in the Far East. He joined the other passengers in protesting the unjustifiable action of the health authorities.¹ The American consul in Japan had given the ship a clean bill of health, and the British Governor of Hong Kong certified to the absence of cholera cases in China.²

He soon discovered that the placing of the ship under quarantine was motivated by politics. The ship was carrying 643 Chinese coolies.³ At that time public opinion on the Pacific coast was against cheap coolie labor because the coolies from China were displacing white laborers in railroad construction camps. To win the votes of the whites in California (for election was near), the administration impeded the entry of Chinese coolies.

Rizal noticed that contrary to quarantine regulations 700 bales of valuable Chinese silk were landed without fumigation, that the ship doctor went ashore without protest on the part of the health officers, and the customs employees ate several times on board the supposedly cholera-infested ship.

After a week of quarantine, all first-class passengers, including Rizal, were permitted to land. But the Chinese and Japanese passengers of the second and third-class accommodations were forced to remain on board for a longer quarantine period.

Rizal in San Francisco. On Friday afternoon, May 4, 1888, the day he was permitted to go ashore, Rizal registered at the Palace Hotel, which was then considered a first-class hotel in the city. On this day, he wrote on his diary:⁴

I lodged in Palace Hotel; \$4 a day with bath and everything included. Stockton St., 312. I saw the Golden Gate. . . . On Sunday the stores are closed. The best Street in San Francisco is Market Street.

Rizal mentioned in his diary the name of Leland Stanford, who was a millionaire senator representing California in the U.S. Senate at that time. This senator was the founder and benefactor of Stanford University at Palo Alto, California. Also recorded in Rizal's diary was a street — Dupont Street — in Chinatown which is Grant Avenue today.

Rizal stayed in San Francisco for two days — May 4 to 6, 1888. The President of the United States at that time was Grover Cleveland.

Across the American Continent. On May 6, 1888 — Sunday, 4:30 P.M. — Rizal left San Francisco for Oakland, nine miles across San Francisco Bay, by ferry boat.

In Oakland, he boarded the train for his trip across the continent. He took his supper at Sacramento for 75¢ and slept in his coach.

Early the following morning (May 7), he awoke and had a good breakfast at Reno, Nevada, now glamourized by American high-pressure propaganda as "The Biggest Little City in the World." Rizal's diary recounts his travel observation as follows:⁵

Monday, May 7. I saw an Indian attired in semi-European suit, and semi-Indian suit, leaning against a wall. Wide

deserts without plants nor trees. Unpopulated. Lonely place. Bare mountains. Sands. A big extension of white land, like chalk. Far from this desert can be seen some blue mountains. It was a fine day. It was warm, and there was still snow on the top of some mountains.

Tuesday, May 8. This is a beautiful morning. We stop from place to place. We are near Ogden. I believe with a good system of irrigation this place could be cultivated. We are at Utah state, the 3rd state we passed over. In approaching Ogden the fields are seen with horses, oxen, and trees. Some small houses are seen from a distance. From Ogden to Denver. The clock is set one hour ahead of time. We are now beginning to see flowers with yellow color on the way. The mountains at a distance are covered with snow. The banks of Salt Lake are more beautiful than other things we saw. The mules are very big. There are mountains in the middle of the lake like the island of Talim in Laguna de Bay. We saw three Mormon boys at Farmington. There were sheep, cows, and horses in the meadows. This region is not thickly populated. A flock of ducks in the lake. . . . Children greeted us at Salt Lake City. In Utah, the women serve at the table. . . . We changed train at Ogden, and we will not have any change until Denver. In Provo I ate much for 75¢. We are passing between two mountains through a narrow channel.

Wednesday, May 9. We are passing through the mountains and rocks along a river; the river is noisy and its noise gives life to the lifeless territory. We woke up at Colorado, the 5th state we crossed over. At 10:30 we climb up a certain height, and this is why snow is seen along the way. There are many pines. We passed through tunnels made of wood to protect the road against snow. Icicles in these tunnels are very bright which gave majestic effect. The porter of the Pullman Car, an American, is a sort of thief. Colorado has more trees than the three states we passed over. There are many horses.

Thursday, May 10. We woke up in Nebraska. The country is a plain. We reached Omaha, a big city — the biggest since we left San Francisco. The Missouri River is twice as wide as the Pasig River in its widest part. It is marshy. . . . The train passed over the Missouri bridge for 2 and 1/2 minutes; the train goes slowly. We are now in Illinois.

Friday, May 11. We woke up near Chicago. The country is cultivated. It shows our nearness to Chicago. We left Chicago at 8:14 Friday night. What I observed in Chicago is that every cigar store has an Indian figure, and always different. (2775 Washington Street, Boston, Miss C.G. Smith).

Saturday, May 12. A good Wagner Car — we were proceeding in a fine day. The country is beautiful and well populated. We shall arrive at the English territory (Canada — Z.) in the afternoon, and we shall soon see Niagara Falls. We stop for some time to see the points that are beautiful; we went to the side below the Falls; I was between two rocks and this is the greatest cascade I ever saw. It is not so beautiful nor so fine as the falls at Los Baños (sic Pagsanjan — Z.); but much bigger, more imposing . . . The cascade has various falls, various parts. We left the place at night. There is a mysterious sound and persistent echo.

Sunday, May 13. We woke up near Albany. This is a big city. The Hudson River which runs along carries many boats. We crossed over a bridge. The landscape is beautiful; and it is not inferior to the best in Europe. We are going along the banks of the Hudson. They are very beautiful although a little more solitary than those of the Pasig . . . The Hudson is wide. Beautiful ships. Sliced granite rocks were paved along the railroads . . . There were beautiful houses between trees. Day fine. Our grand transcontinental trip ended on Sunday, May 13, at 11:10 A.M.

Rizal in New York. On Sunday morning, May 13, Rizal reached New York, thus ending his trip across the American continent. He stayed three days in this city, which he called the "big town". He visited the scenic and historic places. He was awed and inspired by the memorial to George Washington. Of this great American, he wrote to Ponce: "He is a great man who, I think, has no equal in this country".⁶

On May 16, 1888, he left New York for Liverpool on board the *City of Rome*. According to Rizal, this steamer was "the second largest ship in the world, the largest being the *Great Eastern*".⁷ He saw with thrilling sensation the colossal Statue of Liberty on Bedloe Island as his ship steamed out of New York Harbor.

Rizal's Impression of America. Rizal had good and bad impressions of the United States. The good impressions were (1) the material progress of the country as shown in the great cities, huge farms, flourishing industries, and busy factories; (2) the drive and energy of the American people; (3) the natural beauty of the land; (4) the high standard of living; and (5) the opportunities for better life offered to poor immigrants.

One bad impression Rizal had of America was the lack of racial equality. There existed racial prejudice which was inconsistent with the principles of democracy and freedom of which the Americans talk so much but do not practise. Thus he wrote to Ponce: "They do not have true civil liberty. In some states the Negro cannot marry a White woman, nor a White man a Negress. Hatred against the Chinese leads to difficulty for other Asiatics who, like the Japanese, are mistaken for Chinese by the ignorant, and therefore being disliked, too".⁸

In 1890, two years after Rizal's visit to the United States, Jose Alejandro, who was then studying engineering in Belgium, roomed with him on 38 Rue Philippe Champagne, Brussels. Alejandro had never been in America, so that one day he asked Rizal: "What impressions do you have of America?"

"America," answered Rizal, "is the land par excellence of freedom but only for the whites".⁹

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Chapter 14

Rizal in London (1888-89)

After visiting the United States, Rizal lived in London from May, 1888 to March, 1889. He chose this English city to be his new home for three reasons: (1) to improve his knowledge of the English language, (2) to study and annotate Morga's *Sucesos de las Islas Filipinas*, a rare copy of which he heard to be available in the British Museum, and (3) London was a safe place for him to carry on his fight against Spanish tyranny. In London, he engaged in Filipiniana studies, completed annotating Morga's book, wrote many articles for *La Solidaridad* in defense of his people against Spanish critics, penned a famous letter to the young women of Malolos, carried on his voluminous correspondence with Blumentritt and relatives, and had a romance with Gertrude Beckett.

Trip Across the Atlantic. The trans-Atlantic voyage of Rizal from New York to Liverpool was a pleasant one. He won many friends of different nationalities on board the palatial *City of Rome* because of his friendly nature and his ability as a linguist.

Rizal entertained the American and European passengers with his marvelous skill with the yo-yo as an offensive weapon. The yo-yo is a small wooden disc attached to a string from the finger. It is used by Filipino children as a toy. But Rizal manipulated it as a weapon of offense, to the great amazement of the foreigners.¹

On board the steamer were some American newspapermen on their way to Europe. Rizal discussed with them the current social and political problems of mankind, and found them to be inadequate in geo-politics. He could not enjoy their companionship because they were intellectually inferior to him.

Rizal arrived at Liverpool, England, on May 24, 1888. He stayed one day in this port city, spending the night at the Adelphi Hotel. "Liverpool", he wrote to his family, "is a big and beautiful city and its celebrated port is worthy of its great fame. The entrance is magnificent and the customhouse is quite good".²

Life in London. On May 25, 1888, a day after docking, at Liverpool, Rizal went to London. For a short time, he stayed as guest at the home of Dr. Antonio Ma. Regidor, an exile of 1872 and a practising lawyer in London.³ By the end of May, he found a modest boarding place at No. 37 Chalcot Crescent, Primrose Hill.⁴ He was a boarder of the Beckett family.⁵ The Becketts were Mr. Beckett, organist of St. Paul's Church, Mrs. Beckett (his wife), two sons and four daughters. The oldest of the Beckett sisters was Gertrude, called "Gettie" or "Tottie" by her friends.

The Beckett home was to Rizal conveniently located. It was near the public parks and was within easy walking distance to the British Museum where he expected to do much research work.

Rizal came to know Dr. Reinhold Rost, the librarian of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and an authority on Malayan languages and customs. Dr. Rost was impressed by Rizal's learning and character, and he gladly recommended him to the authorities of the British Museum. He called Rizal "a pearl of a man" (*una perla de hombre*).⁶

Rizal spent much of his time in the British Museum poring over the pages of Morga's *Sucesos* and other rare historical works on the Philippines. He frequently visited Dr. Regidor and discussed with him problems pertaining to Philippine affairs.

He spent Sundays in the house of Dr. Rost, with whom he had many pleasant discussions on linguistics. He also played cricket (popular English game) and boxed with Dr. Rost's sons.

News from Home, Good and Bad. Both good and bad news from home reached Rizal in London. Of the bad news, were the injustices committed by the Spanish authorities on the Filipino people and the Rizal family. Among which were as follows:

1. Persecution of the Filipino patriots who signed the "Anti-Friar Petition of 1888" which was presented by Doroteo Cortes, prominent Mason and lawyer, to Jose

Centeno, Civil Governor of the Province of Manila, on March 1, 1888. This petition was signed by about 800 patriots and was actually written by M.H. del Pilar. It was addressed to the Queen Regent of Spain requesting the expulsion of the friars, including Archbishop Pedro Payo (Dominican)⁷ of Manila.

2. Persecution of the Calamba tenants, including Rizal's family and relatives, for their courage to petition the government for agrarian reforms.

3. Furious attacks on Rizal by Senators Salamanca and Vida in the Spanish Cortes and by Desengañados (Wenceslao E. Retana) and Quioquiap (Pablo Feced) in Spanish newspapers.

4. Rizal's brother-in-law, Manuel T. Hidalgo, husband of Saturnina, was exiled by Governor General Weyler to Bohol without due process of law.

5. A friend of Rizal, Laureano Viado, a medical student at the University of Santo Tomas, was arrested and jailed in Bilibid Prison because copies of the *Noli* were found in his house.

One good news cheered Rizal, and that was Rev. Vicente Garcia's defense of the *Noli* against the attacks of the friars. He heard this good news from Mariano Ponce. He was deeply gratified by the courageous action of Father Garcia, a venerable Filipino canon of the Manila Cathedral. Later, On January 7, 1891, he wrote to Father Garcia, expressing his personal thanks. In this famous letter, he said:⁸

We young Filipinos are trying to make over a nation and must not halt in our onward march, but from time to time turn our gaze upon our elders. We shall wish to read in their countenances approval of our actions. We are anxious to learn of the Philippines' past which we need to understand in order to plan intelligently for the future. We want to know all that our ancestors knew, and then add our own studies to theirs. Thus we shall progress the faster because we can go on from where they left off.

Annotating Morga's Book. The greatest achievement of Rizal in London was the annotating of Morga's book, *Sucesos de las Islas Filipinas* (Historical Events of the Philippine Islands) which was published in Mexico, 1609. He spent many days in

the reading room of the British Museum poring over the pages of this book and laboriously reading the old histories of the Philippines, such as those written by Fr. Chirino, Fr. Colin, Fr. Argensola, Fr. Plasencia, etc. Of all written histories published during the early years of the Spanish regime, that of Dr. Morga was, in his considered opinion, the best.

In a letter to Blumentritt, dated September 17, 1888, Rizal said: "Morga's work is an excellent book; it can be said that Morga is a modern scholarly explorer. He does not have the superficiality and exaggeration which are found among Spaniards today: he writes very simply, but one has to read between the lines"⁹

For about ten months (May 1888-March 1889), Rizal was deeply immersed in his historical studies in London. During which time his compatriots in Spain were waging the crusade for Philippine reforms. At one time, Mariano Ponce, whom he had never yet met and who was then living in Barcelona, urged him to edit a newspaper which would defend the Filipino interests from the scurrilous attacks of their Spanish detractors. He refused Ponce's request because he was busy. "Today," he wrote to Ponce on October 12, 1888, "I am dedicated day and night to certain studies, so that I do not want to edit any newspaper".¹⁰

Short Visit to Paris and Spain. Early in September, 1888, he visited Paris for a week, in order to search for more historical materials in the Bibliotheque Nationale. He was entertained in this gay French metropolis by Juan Luna and his wife (Paz Pardo de Tavera), who proudly showed him their little son Andres (nickname Luling). After poring over the old books and manuscript in the Bibliotheque Nationale, he returned to London.

On December 11, 1888, he went to Spain, visiting Madrid and Barcelona. He contacted his compatriots and surveyed the political situation with regards to the agitation for Philippine reforms. For the first time, he met Marcelo H. del Pilar and Mariano Ponce, two titans of the Propaganda Movement. He exchanged ideas with these new friends and promised to cooperate in the fight for reforms.

Christmas in London (1888). Rizal returned to London on December 24 and spent Christmas and New Year's Day with the Becketts. He experienced a delightful Christmas Eve, his

first on English soil. That night he wrote to Blumentritt: "it is now Noche-Buena (Christmas Eve); it is the holiday I like best to celebrate. It reminds me of the many good days not only of my infancy, but also of history. Whether or not Christ was born exactly on this day, I do not know; but exact chronology is immaterial to see the joy of this night. A great Genius was born who preached truth and love. He suffered on account of His mission, but because of His sufferings the world had improved, if not saved. How it shocks me to see people misuse His name to commit many crimes".¹¹

To his friend, Blumentritt, Rizal sent as Christmas gift a bust of Emperor Augustus which he had made. This emperor was the ruler of the Roman Empire when Jesus Christ was born in Bethlehem. To another friend, Dr. Carlos Czepelak (Polish scholar), he gave as Christmas gift a bust of Julius Caesar.

Rizal's landlady, Mrs. Beckett, knowing of his interest in magic, gave him as Christmas gift a book entitled *The Life and Adventures of Valentine Vox, the Ventriloquist*. Rizal was delighted to receive this book, for he had great admiration for this British magician who was famous for his ventriloquism.

Rizal Becomes leader of Filipinos in Europe. While busy in his historical studies in London, Rizal learned that the Filipinos in Barcelona were planning to establish a patriotic society which would cooperate in the crusade for reforms. This society, called *Asociacion La Solidaridad* (Solidaridad Association), was inaugurated on December 31, 1888, with the following officers: Galicano Apacible, president; Graciano Lopez Jaena, vice-president; Manuel Santa Maria, secretary; Mariano Ponce, treasurer; and Jose Ma. Panganiban, accountant.

By unanimous vote of all the members, Rizal was chosen honorary president. This was a recognition of his leadership among all Filipino patriots in Europe.

As the leader of his countrymen in Europe, Rizal wrote a letter addressed to the members of the *Asociacion La Solidaridad*, on January 28, 1889. In this letter, he expressed his thanks for the honor of making him honorary president and gave the following advice:¹²

1. In young associations the spirit of tolerance ought to prevail when it concerns trifles that do not affect the

essential part of a thing; in the discussions, the conciliatory tendency ought to dominate before the tendency to oppose. No one should resent defeat. When any opinion is rejected, its author, instead of despairing and withdrawing, should on the contrary wait for another occasion in which justice may be done him. The individual should give way to the welfare of the society.

2. A great deal of integrity and much good will. No member should expect rewards or honors for what he does. He who does his duty in the expectation of rewards, is usually disappointed, because almost no one believes himself sufficiently rewarded. And so that there may not be discontented or ill-rewarded members, it is advisable for each one to do his duty just for its own sake and at best expect to be later treated unjustly, because in anomalous countries, injustice is the prize for those who fulfill their duties.

Thrift, thrift, thrift.

Seriousness and equal justice for all.

Rizal and The La Solidaridad Newspaper. On February 15, 1889, Graciano Lopez Jaena founded the patriotic newspaper called *La Solidaridad* in Barcelona, where he was then residing. This was a fortnightly periodical which served as the organ of the Propaganda Movement. Its aims were as follows: (1) to work peacefully for political and social reforms; (2) to portray the deplorable conditions of the Philippines so that Spain may remedy them; (3) to oppose the evil forces of reaction and medievalism; (4) to advocate liberal ideas and progress; and (5) to champion the legitimate aspirations of the Filipino people to life, democracy, and happiness.

Two days after the birth of *La Solidaridad*, M.H. del Pilar wrote to Rizal in London: "At last our little newspaper was born. It is democratic in its opinion, but very much more so in the organization of its staff. One should see how editor Graciano writes, corrects proofs, directs the printing, distributes the copies, and even takes them to the mail. Naning [Mariano Ponce — Z.], the manager, gathers the data, edits, corrects the proofs, writes the leads, prepares the correspondence, and also distributes the copies. I am the only idler, though the newspaper had me preoccupied during the period of its conception and birth, for which reason I am behind in my correspondence with you".¹³

Rizal congratulated Lopez Jaena and his associates in founding *La Solidaridad*. As evidence of his approval and cooperation, he prepared articles for the periodical which were subsequently published. In his letter to Lopez Jaena, he advised him that great care should be taken in publishing only the truth in *La Solidaridad*. "Be careful", he admonished, "not to publish exaggerations or lies or imitate others, who avail themselves of dishonest means and of vulgar and ignoble language to attain their ends. See that the periodical is just, honest, and truthful so that its opinion may always be respected. It is necessary that we show our enemies that we are more worthy than they, morally and humanly speaking. Should we tell the truth we shall have won our cause because reason and justice are on our side. There is no need for knaveries".¹⁴

First Article in *La Solidaridad*. Rizal's first article which appeared in *La Solidaridad* was entitled *Los Agricultores Filipinos* (The Filipino Farmers). It was published on March 25, 1889, six days after he left London for Paris.

In this initial article, he depicted the deplorable conditions in the Philippines which cause the backwardness of the country. He wrote:¹⁵

The Filipino farmer has to struggle not only against petty tyrants and robbers. Against the first, defense indeed is permitted; against the latter, not always . . .

After the floods, locusts, fires, bad harvests, and the like, the farmer capitalist has to deal with the constable who takes away from him his laborers for personal service, some public works, repair of roads, bridges, and others; with the civil guard who arrests them for various reasons, sometimes for not carrying with them their personal cedula (certificates) for not saluting properly, for being suspicious persons or for no reason whatsoever, and they manacle them to clean the barracks and thus compel the capitalist to live on better terms with the chief and, if not, they take away his carabao, oxen, in spite of many protests . . .

At times it is not the constable or the civil guard who opposes so indirectly the minister of colonies. An official of the court or of the provincial government, dissatisfied with the farmer, urgently summons this or that laborer, if not two or three. The unfortunate man undertakes a trip

of two or three days, uneasy and distrustful, spends his savings, arrives, presents himself, waits, returns the next day and waits, finally to be asked with a frown and the look of a judge, abstruse and unknown things. He is lucky if he comes out free from the questioning, for not infrequently after it, he is sent to jail from which he comes out later as stupid as before . . ."

Writings in London. While busy in research studies at the British Museum, Rizal received news on Fray Rodriguez' unabated attack on his *Noli*. In defense, he wrote a pamphlet entitled *La Vision del Fray Rodriguez* (The Vision of Fray Rodriguez) which was published in Barcelona under his nom-de-plume *Dimas Alang*. This opus is a satire depicting a spirited dialogue between St. Augustine and Fr. Rodriguez. St. Augustine told Fr. Rodriguez that he (St. Augustine) was commissioned by God to tell him (Fr. Rodriguez) of his stupidity and inform him of his penance on earth that he (Fr. Rodriguez) shall continue to write more stupidity so that all men may laugh at him.

In *La Vision del Fray Rodriguez*, Rizal demonstrated two things: (1) his profound knowledge of religion and (2) his biting satire.

In London, Rizal wrote the famous "Letter to the Young Women of Malolos" (February 22, 1889) in Tagalog.¹⁶ He penned it, upon the request of M.H. del Pilar to praise the young ladies of Malolos for their courage to establish a school where they could learn Spanish, despite the opposition of Fr. Felipe Garcia, Spanish parish priest of Malolos. The main points of this letter were: (1) a Filipino mother should teach her children love of God, fatherland, and mankind; (2) the Filipino mother should be glad, like the Spartan mother, to offer her sons in the defense of the fatherland; (3) a Filipino woman should know how to preserve her dignity and honor; (4) a Filipino woman should educate herself, aside from retaining her good racial virtues; and (5) Faith is not merely reciting long prayers and wearing religious pictures, but rather it is living the real Christian way, with good morals and good manners.

Dr. Rost, editor of *Trubner's Record*, a journal devoted to Asian studies, requested Rizal to contribute some articles. In response to his request, the latter prepared two articles — (1)

"Specimens of Tagal Folklore" which was published in the journal in May, 1889; and (2) "Two Eastern Fables", published in June, 1889.¹⁷

The first article consisted of Filipino proverbs and puzzles, as follows:¹⁸

I. Proverbial Sayings

Malakas ang bulong sa sigaw, Low words are stronger than loud words.

Ang laki sa layaw karaniwa'y hubad, A petted child is generally naked (i.e. poor)

Hampas ng magulang ay nakatataba, Parent's punishment makes one fat.

Ibang hari ibang ugali, New king, new fashion.

Nagpuputol ang kapus, ang labis ay nagdurugtong, What is short cuts off a piece from itself, what is long adds another on (the poor gets poorer, the rich richer).

Ang nagsasabi ng tapos ay siyang kinakapus, He who finishes his words finds himself wanting.

Nangangako habang napapako, Man promises while in need.

Ang naglalakad ng marahan, matinik ma'y mababaw, He who walks slowly, though he may put his foot on a thorn, will not be hurt very much (Tagals mostly go barefooted).

Ang maniwala sa sabi'y walang bait sa sarili, He who believes in tales has no own mind.

Ang may isinuksok sa dingding, ay may titingalain, He who has put something between the walls may afterwards look on (the saving man may afterwards be cheerful). — The wall of a Tagal house is made of palm-leaves and bamboo, so that it can be used as a cupboard.

Walang mahirap gisingin na paris nang nagtutologtulugan, The most difficult to rouse from sleep is the man who pretends to be asleep.

Labis sa salita, kapus sa gawa, Too many words, too little work.

Hipong tulog ay nadadala ng anod, The sleeping shrimp is carried away by the current.

Sa bibig nahuhuli ang isda, The fish is caught through the mouth.

II. Puzzles

Isang butil na palay sikip sa buong bahay, One rice-corn fills up all the house. — The light. The rice-corn with the husk is yellowish.

Matapang ako sa dalawa, duwag ako sa isa, I am brave against two, coward against one. — The bamboo bridge. When the bridge is made of one bamboo only, it is difficult to pass over; but when it's made of two or more it is very easy.

Dala ako niya, dala ko siya, He carries me, I carry him. — The shoes.

Isang balong malalim puno ng patalim, A deep well filled with steel blades. — The mouth.

Romance with Gertrude Beckett. Rizal had a romantic interlude with the oldest of the three Beckett sisters — Gertrude, Gettie, as she was affectionately called, was a buxom English girl with brown hair, blue eyes, and rosy cheeks. She fell in love with Rizal. On cold winter mornings she had a sunny smile for him, chattering gaily like a humming bird. During the family picnics, she was particularly very happy because Rizal was with them and she gave him all her attention. And in rainy days when Rizal stayed at home, she helped him by mixing his colors for painting or assisted in preparing the clay for sculpturing.

Rizal, being a man of normal emotions, found exhilarating joy in Gertrude's company. Their friendship drifted towards romance. Rizal affectionately called her "Gettie," in reciprocation, she fondly called him "Pettie." As their flirtation was fast approaching the point of no return, Rizal suddenly realized that he could not marry Gettie for he had a mission to fulfill in life.

With iron will, he suppressed the passionate yearning of his heart, and decided to go away so that "Gettie" may forget him.¹⁹ Before leaving London, he finished four sculptural works — (1) Prometheus Bound, (2) "The Triumph of Death over Life," (3) "The Triumph of Science over Death," and (4) a composite carving of the heads of the Beckett sisters. The last-named carving he gave as a farewell gift to the Beckett sisters. He packed "The

Triumph of Death over Life" and "The Triumph of Science over Death" and sent them to his friend, Professor Bluementritt, in Leitmeritz.

Adios, London. Suddenly on March 19, 1889, Rizal bade goodbye to the kind Beckett family (particularly Gertrude) and left London for Paris. He was sad as he crossed the English Channel, for he cherished so many beautiful memories of London.

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Chapter 15

Rizal's Second Sojourn in Paris and the Universal Exposition of 1889

Paris in the spring of 1889 was bursting with gaiety and excitement because of the Universal Exposition. Thousands of visitors from all corners of the world crowded every hotel, inn, and boarding house. Everywhere in the metropolis the hotel rates and house rents were soaring skyhigh. Rizal, fresh from London, was caught in the whirl of gay Parisian life. Despite the social parties and the glittering lights of the city, he continued his fruitful artistic, literary, and patriotic labors. He published his annotated edition of Morga's *Sucesos*; founded three Filipino societies, the Kidlat Club, the Indios Bravos, and the R.D.L.M.; and wrote *Por Telefono*, a satire against Fr. Salvador Font.

Difficulty of Finding Quarters. In March 1889, it was extremely difficult for a visitor to find living quarters in Paris. The approaching Universal Exposition of 1889 which was scheduled to open on May 6, 1889 attracted thousands of tourists so that all hotel accommodations were taken. To the great disgust of Rizal, the cost of living spiralled high because the French landlords, taking advantage of the great demand for living quarters, raised the rents of their rooms.

For a short time, Rizal lived in the house of his friend Valentin Ventura, at No. 45 Rue Maubeuge, where he polished his annotated edition of Morga's book. He transferred his residence several times, moving from one hotel to another, from one boarding house to another.